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Democratic hypocrisy in practice: a panel study of revealed preferences for liberal democracy in Poland

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ABSTRACT

Democratic hypocrisy – the tendency for citizens to express support for democratic norms in the abstract while tolerating violations of those norms when doing so serves their partisan interests – has been identified as a potential threat to liberal democracy in conditions of affective polarisation. Yet existing research has relied on declared preferences, leaving open the question of whether such hypocrisy manifests itself in the kinds of multidimensional choices that characterise real political decision-making. Using a conjoint experiment embedded in a three-wave panel survey spanning Poland’s transition from illiberal PiS incumbency to a pro-democratic KO-led coalition government, I examine whether citizens’ revealed preferences for liberal democracy change when power changes hands. Results show that Polish citizens consistently punish candidates who espouse illiberal views, and that this tendency is not significantly altered by the change of government, even among citizens who are highly affectively polarised. Contrary to expectations, citizens polarised in favour of the former incumbent party did not become more protective of liberal-democratic norms after losing power. These findings suggest that revealed preferences for liberal democracy are more stable than theories of democratic hypocrisy would predict, but also that democratic restoration cannot rely on a natural correction in public attitudes following a change of government.

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Introduction

Following the victory of the nationalist-populist Law and Justice (Prawo i Sprawiedliwość; PiS) party in the general election of October 2015, Poland – previously seen as one of the success stories of post-1989 transition to democracy – experienced a precipitous decline in the quality of its liberal democratic institutions, falling from 0.79 to 0.42 on the V-Dem Liberal Democracy index and being re-classified as an “electoral democracy” (Coppedge et al. 2024).

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PiS's attack on Poland's political and institutional establishment saw public media swiftly colonised, purged of dissenting voices and turned into a crude instrument of government propaganda (Bill and Stanley 2020). State-held enterprises were rich sources of patronage for the emerging "counterelite", which was also cultivated through the politicisation of civil society (Bill 2020). The Constitutional Tribunal was paralysed and then captured through the appointment of politically loyal justices, enabling PiS to establish what amounted to an alternative legal reality in which subsequent changes, most importantly the politicisation of apex judicial institutions, were granted the dignity of official validation, however legally spurious (Pirro and Stanley 2021; Sadurski 2019).

These actions brought PiS into conflict with the European Union, with the Commission deploying its rule-of-law procedures and taking repeated action against Poland in the European Court of Justice (Pech, Wachowiec, and Mazur 2021). By the end of PiS's first term in 2019, the norms and procedures of liberal democracy had given way to executive decisionism, with PiS leader Jarosław Kaczyński, whose control of his party went unchallenged, essentially ruling without responsibility. Yet, in the absence of a supermajority, PiS was unable to entrench its power as firmly and irrevocably as Fidesz in Hungary, and Poland remained a functioning electoral democracy, free if not entirely fair, with an opposition that struggled to match PiS individually but collectively remained a plausible alternative. In the 2023 election, a "pro-democratic coalition" led by Donald Tusk's Civic Coalition (Koalicja Obywatelska, KO) unseated PiS and embarked on the difficult task of restoring liberal democracy in Poland in the face of significant structural barriers erected by their predecessors, increasing impatience from the government's own supporters, and the constraints of what Bill and Stanley (2025a) have termed a "post-illiberal trilemma" in which governments seeking to deal with the consequences of democratic backsliding face incentives to act effectively, legally, and quickly, but can realistically achieve only two of these three goals at once.

The emergence of cases of "democratic illiberalism" (Smilova 2021) in several contemporary democracies has stimulated interest in the stability and sincerity of the liberal-democratic attitudes professed by voters in both the affected countries and beyond. Yet little is known about the dynamics of support for liberal democracy when liberal-democratic and illiberal forces alternate in power, for the simple reason that we have observed few cases of this happening. The goal of this article is to ascertain whether revealed preferences for liberal democracy remain consistently held across such a change of power.

The understanding of liberal democracy used in this article follows the definition employed by the Varieties of Democracy project (Coppedge et al. 2024). This approach combines a definition of democracy as a polyarchic system characterised by free and fair competition for the electorate's vote with a "negative" conception of political power. By this measure, democracy is understood as limiting the writ of the executive through preserving constitutional protections for civil liberties, the rule of law, the independence of the judiciary, and a system of checks and balances. Recent research has found that citizens' attitudes and actions with respect to democratic backsliding are shaped not only by liberal democratic ideas but by alternative conceptions of democracy (Kaftan and Gessler 2025; Wunsch, Jacob, and Derksen 2025). However, the focus on liberal democracy in this case is motivated by two linked considerations.

Firstly, the assault on democracy conducted by the PiS governments from 2015 to 2023 was by design an attack on normative principles and political institutions created in

accordance with an explicitly liberal conception of democracy. As Kaczyński, the chief architect of PiS's backsliding agenda, put it, liberal democracy equated to a system of "impossibilism" that acted to thwart the will of the sovereign (Bill and Stanley 2025b, 20). Secondly, the response of the Polish electorate to the integrity of liberal-democratic norms and institutions is particularly salient in the context of the challenging task of post-illiberal reform.

Subordinating the rule of law, media freedoms and individual and collective liberties to executive decisionism may be attractive for illiberals when their preferred party controls the executive. However, they may be tempted to pay at least "lip service" to liberal democracy in circumstances where they have a greater need of the protections it affords them. Similarly, supporters of parties that are committed to liberal democracy may evince less of an attachment to those norms and institutions when those parties are in power, having less need of its protections and experiencing greater frustration at the constraints it imposes. To understand the difficulties faced by post-illiberal reform of the kind ongoing in Poland and likely to be needed elsewhere, it is necessary to attend not only to the question of whether political elites are sufficiently invested in liberal democracy to restore it, but also whether restoring liberal democracy is something the electorate requires of them.

In pursuit of this objective, I use data from a three-wave panel survey conducted in Poland in April 2023 (when PiS was the incumbent party), October 2023 (when PiS was still the incumbent party, shortly before the parliamentary election), and April 2024 (when the KO-led coalition was the incumbent party, following its formation in December 2023). These data contain questions on political preferences, attitudes to liberal democracy, ideological positions, and an embedded forced-choice conjoint experiment measuring the impact of candidates' illiberal policy stances on voters' willingness to choose them. In the following section, I develop my hypotheses with reference to ongoing research into the stability of attitudes towards liberal democracy. I then discuss the research design and methods, present key findings, and discuss their implications.

The article makes three contributions to the study of democratic hypocrisy. First, it moves beyond the analysis of declared preferences to examine *revealed* preferences for liberal democracy, providing a more demanding test of whether citizens are willing to tolerate illiberalism when faced with the kinds of trade-offs that characterise real political choices. Second, it uses panel data spanning an actual change of government, moving beyond cross-sectional designs to examine whether and how citizens' democratic preferences shift when power changes hands. Third, it situates democratic hypocrisy in the context of post-illiberal reform, a topic of growing practical importance as cases of arrested or reversed democratic backsliding become more common, and one that requires us to understand not only what citizens say about liberal democracy but what they are willing to do about it.

Democratic hypocrisy, affective polarisation, and the instrumentalising of liberal democracy

In a recent overview of events in European democracies, Bartels argues that "democracy erodes from the top", with political elites the protagonists and citizens "little more than passive bystanders" (Bartels 2023, 25). Yet as Cohen et al. (2023, 264) put it, "citizens

are not always naive victims” and the victory of illiberal forces “suggests a critical mass of amenable voters” who are willing to overlook the violation of liberal-democratic norms even if they have not actively solicited such an agenda. If erosion is a top-down process, it is facilitated by weaknesses below. The electoral success of PiS and other illiberal parties has provoked discussion of the extent to which liberal democracy is vulnerable not so much to citizens’ hostility toward its key predicates, but to inattention and indifference in the face of a popular conception of democracy that prioritises outcomes over procedures. As one contributor to the debate sparked by Bartels has speculated, it is possible that the flourishing of liberal democracy in the post-1989 era was largely “a mirage ... optimistically mistaken for the real thing” (Nooruddin, in Bartels et al. 2023, 17). This echoes the earlier conclusions of Dawson and Hanley (2016, 21) that post-1989 Central and Eastern Europe was marked by an absence of “genuinely liberal political platforms ... based on shared commitments to the norms of political equality, individual liberty, civic tolerance and the rule of law”. If a robust articulation of liberal democracy is in short supply, it is plausible to suppose that there is limited demand for it too.

An influential recent study of the links between polarisation and democratic backsliding concludes that rather than because of an incapacity “to recognise a subversion of democracy for what it is” or a disinclination to “care much about democracy in the first place” voters are failing to punish political elites who depart from liberal-democratic norms because “deep social cleavages and acute political tensions ... undercut the public’s ability to curb the illiberal inclinations of elected politicians” (Svolik 2019, 21–24). Contemporary democracies are vulnerable to subversion not because of disenchantment with liberal democracy itself, but because the partisan force of “pernicious polarisation” (Somer, McCoy, and Luke 2021, 930) trumps respect for the system of rights and restraints through which that political system functions.

While citizens generally condemn democratic violations by public officials (Wunsch and Gessler 2023, 916), authoritarian winners’ support for the political system “is at best contingent” (Cohen et al. 2023, 273), and there is a greater propensity among supporters of opposition parties “to stand up for democratic checks and balances” (Mazepus and Toshkov 2021, 1291). There is increasing evidence that voters are willing to accept anti-democratic actions if those actions benefit their preferred party (Fossati, Muhtadi, and Warburton 2021; Şaşmaz, Yagci, and Ziblatt 2022), particularly in the presence of strong partisanship (Bryan 2023), when democratic principles may be sacrificed to partisan interests, with those in power reconceptualising democracy in illiberal terms, emphasising authoritarian solutions (which favour their party’s agenda) and depreciating civil rights (which favour the agenda of those without power). Alarmingly, such partisan biases may be consequential even in unstable party systems with considerable voter volatility (Hrbková, Voda, and Havlík 2023).

The emerging literature on “democratic hypocrisy” (Simonovits, McCoy, and Littvay 2022) goes beyond theories of partisan “undercutting” of liberal democratic norms to suggest more active complicity on the part of democratic publics in perpetuating illiberalism. Democratic hypocrisy can be defined as the tendency for citizens to express support for democratic norms in the abstract while tolerating or even endorsing violations of those norms when doing so serves their partisan interests. It entails a gap between declared and revealed preferences for liberal democracy that is contingent on which party holds power. In contemporary Poland, where political debates are not only

charged with affective polarisation (Górska 2019) but by the metapolitical question of the very legitimacy of Poland's post-1989 transition to democracy (Bill 2020), there is abundant potential for such outcomes. Indeed Svulik et al. (2023) – echoing earlier work in the US context (Gidengil, Stolle, and Bergeron-Boutin 2022; Graham and Svulik 2020) – find that those who vote for radical right parties in Poland are more likely to fail to punish hypothetical candidates for transgressions against liberal democracy. More broadly, in a study of support for liberal democracy in 28 European democracies van der Brug et al. (2021) find clear evidence of an incumbency effect, whereby supporters of incumbent parties – particularly, but not exclusively those of the radical right – are less likely than supporters of opposition parties to support key liberal-democratic norms and institutions.

These studies have expanded our understanding of the relationship between political partisanship and preferences – both declared and revealed – for liberal democracy. However, while they furnish a basis for hypothesising that voters might treat liberal democratic principles in instrumental fashion following a change of government, we know little about whether this actually happens. There have been few cases to date of democratic backsliding giving way to a period of liberal-democratic reconsolidation, and almost no studies drawing on longitudinal data spanning a change of government. A recent exception is a study of the US case by Littvay, McCoy, and Simonovits (2024, 9), which finds that after a change of the executive, supporters of the Democrats are willing to join those of the Republicans in “look[ing] the other way when their own party leaders act uninhibited by existing norms”. This study shows that observation of democratic norms is prone to vary across a change of power. In this sense it overcomes one of the deficiencies of earlier studies, in that it replaces hypothetical scenarios with real-life context. Yet by concentrating on declared preferences it retains a hypothetical character, as it presents choices about whether to observe democratic norms in isolation from other important considerations. A change in the extent to which citizens support the erosion of liberal democratic norms may ultimately be of little moment for democracy if voters' decisions are driven by other concerns.

A crucial distinction thus emerges between declared and revealed preferences for liberal democracy. When citizens are asked directly whether they support democratic norms, they respond in isolation from the trade-offs that characterise real political choices. Yet in practice, voters do not choose between democracy and its absence in the abstract: they choose between candidates who bundle together positions on democratic norms with stances on economic policy, social issues, and other matters of concern. Revealed preferences, as captured by conjoint experiments that embed illiberal positions within realistic candidate profiles, force respondents to weigh democratic norms against these competing considerations. This distinction is consequential for the study of democratic hypocrisy, because the gap between declared and revealed preferences may itself vary with context. When the cost of expressing partisan bias is limited to a survey response, democratic hypocrisy may manifest itself readily. When it requires accepting a candidate whose other attributes may be unappealing, partisans face a harder choice, and the resulting behaviour may differ. A conjoint design thus provides a more conservative but arguably more realistic test of democratic hypocrisy, capturing preferences as they are likely to be expressed in the kinds of multidimensional choices that voters actually face.

This study moves beyond the identification of democratic hypocrisy on the basis of declared preferences to answer the question of whether citizens' revealed preferences for democratic norms vary as power changes hands. The existing literature supports the expectation that in conditions of strong affective polarisation liberal democratic norms are likely to be observed in an instrumental rather than sincere fashion, and that this will affect both winners and losers of elections. As Cox, Cubillos, and Foulon (2025) show in the case of Chile, even in conditions of weak partisanship the priming of affective polarisation can serve to induce reduced support for democracy. Where partisanship is well-established and strong, and is already expressed through affective polarisation, the loser of an election is more likely to perceive the winning side not merely as a competitor but as a threat (McCoy, Rahman, and Somer 2018, 26; Simonovits, McCoy, and Littvay 2022, 1807). Since liberal-democratic institutions are *inter alia* designed to protect minorities – among them the losers of elections – from the overweening force of executive power, election losers in conditions of partisan threat perception should be more motivated to support the integrity of liberal democratic institutions and the norms by which they operate.

For election winners, a recent history of democratic backsliding creates a different set of dilemmas and incentives. Those who have won an election on the promise to defend liberal democracy will face the prospect of reputational losses if they fail to come good. Yet there are countervailing pressures. Among political elites, the attempt to restore the integrity of institutions is often a frustrating and politically thankless experience. The temptation to cut through the Gordian knots of legal complexity bequeathed by illiberal predecessors rather than patiently unpick them is great, particularly for those convinced that the moral ends excuse the means. As Bill and Stanley (2025a, 25) document in the Polish case, the Tusk government explicitly invoked the concept of “militant democracy” to justify actions that might be “inconsistent with the letter of the law”, while survey evidence from the same period shows that a majority of strong KO supporters were – at least declaratively – willing to endorse government actions of dubious legality if the preceding government had acted similarly. A more militant approach may also commend itself to supporters of parties elected on a mandate to reckon with the actions of their predecessors.

Most troublingly, the recalibration of acceptable norms and conduct that occurs during a spell of backsliding may simply lead less principled elites and voters alike to conclude that there is more to be gained from “playing politics on easy mode”. Strong forms of illiberalism may serve to normalise its more moderate manifestation in the shape of a softer, less blatant kind of executive decisionism, with the risk that “replicating the illiberal *modus operandi*” embeds a Schmittean logic of “deciding on the exception” as a legitimate mode of governance (Bill and Stanley 2025a, 28). Affective polarisation can serve to excuse the sins of “our side” as much as to magnify the sins of “the other side”, and in conditions of elite frustration and popular impatience this may erode adherence to liberal-democratic norms in subtler but no less damaging fashion.

Accordingly, I forward the following hypotheses. Firstly, I expect that in a liberal democracy where persistent majorities of voters still express a preference for democracy as a system of government, the average citizen will punish candidates who express illiberal views (H1). This may at first glance seem counter-intuitive with respect to the foregoing discussion: if affective polarisation matters, then we should expect to see higher

support for illiberalism. Yet if acceptance of illiberalism is influenced both positively and negatively by affective polarisation, this should be reflected in a net lack of change across the three waves of the survey in the aggregate extent to which illiberalism influences voters' decision-making. However, if affective polarisation matters, then this general tendency to punish illiberalism will disguise significant heterogeneity once responses are broken down by party preference. In line with the theory that affective polarisation leads to an instrumentalisation of liberal democratic norms and institutions, I therefore expect that citizens who are affectively polarised in favour of PiS will be less likely than those affectively polarised in favour of KO to punish candidates for holding illiberal views prior to the change of government, when PiS was the incumbent party (H2a), but more likely to do so after the change of government, when the KO-led coalition became the incumbent party (H2b).

However, to understand whether democratic hypocrisy is at work, as opposed to pure affective polarisation, we also need to incorporate declared attitudes to liberal democracy. If only those with little commitment to liberal democracy punish or reward illiberal candidates in accordance with their partisan advantage, this is consistent opportunism rather than hypocrisy. If on the other hand even those citizens with pro-liberal-democratic views punish or reward candidates differently depending on the partisan advantages to be gained, this is evidence of democratic hypocrisy. As such, I hypothesise that the relationships between affective polarisation and voting for illiberals set out in H2 will apply regardless of a citizen's declared level of support for liberal democracy (H3).

Research design and methods

To test these hypotheses, I use conjoint analyses embedded in an online (CAWI) panel survey tracking Poles' attitudes to and behaviours concerning liberal democracy over a 12-month period, carried out by the Polish survey agency PBS. The survey was conducted in three waves: Wave 1 in April 2023 (PiS incumbent), Wave 2 in October 2023 (PiS incumbent, shortly before the parliamentary election of 15 October 2023), and Wave 3 in April 2024 (KO-led coalition incumbent, following the formation of the new government in December 2023). The change of government between Waves 2 and 3 is thus the key transition that allows me to examine whether support for violations of democratic norms changes when the respondent's own party moves from power to opposition, or vice versa.

These data were collected using quota sampling with the aim of obtaining a representative sample of the population in the third wave. This involved oversampling younger respondents and those with lower levels of education in the preceding waves, as attrition rates are known to be higher in these demographics. This study uses the sample of the 1,503 respondents who participated in all three waves of the survey. It closely approximates the Polish population with respect to gender and region, and acceptably with respect to place of residence, but respondents aged 65 or more are undersampled by 13.9 percentage points relative to population statistics, while those with primary education remain significantly oversampled in the final wave, by 19.1 percentage points. While no quota was applied for political parties, a comparison of responses to the "Sunday vote" question in the third wave suggests that the final sample acceptably reflects political preferences, with a slight undersampling of KO (−1.91%) and PiS (−2.66%) relative to pooled polling in April 2024 (Politico 2024). A detailed table of

these figures is provided in Table A1 in the appendix. Poststratification weights are applied in the following analyses to compensate for these discrepancies.

I use forced-choice conjoint models to identify the relationships between candidate characteristics and vote choice and the mediating role of voter characteristics and attitudes. Conjoint models have two key qualities which are useful for the analysis at hand. First, they incorporate the multidimensional character of decision-making into an analysis of vote choices. By allowing the researcher to vary a number of factors in a single experiment, conjoint analysis makes it possible to estimate the impact of multiple components of an experimental treatment in the determination of an outcome, enabling the simultaneous testing of competing hypotheses (Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto 2014). Second, by giving respondents a variety of reasons to justify their choices, conjoint experiments mitigate the social desirability problems that often afflict experiments where the sole treatment concerns a variable susceptible to such problems. They are thus particularly advantageous when analysing the impact of illiberalism on vote choice, given the normatively positive associations of democracy in liberal-democratic polities.

I use a paired conjoint design in which two candidates are presented to the respondent, with each respondent carrying out 10 separate choice tasks. Given 1,503 respondents and a maximum of 10 variable levels this design has 96% statistical power to detect an effect size of 0.05 (Stefanelli and Lukac 2020). To increase the realism of the choice sets and to ensure that respondents make a fuller consideration of candidates than a pure focus on policy allows, I include information on several factors that are likely to be of relevance in the evaluation of candidates' suitability for office. Political experience distinguishes candidates with 8 years of experience (two parliamentary terms in the Polish case), 4 years of experience, and new candidates without prior experience. Chance of getting elected distinguishes between those who are unlikely to get elected, those who have a possibility of getting elected, and those who will probably get elected. Gender distinguishes between male and female candidates, and Age ranges from 23 to 57 years old, with three intermediate categories. For each of these variables there is also a "no information" option.

Each candidate is associated with three policy positions. The first two policy positions are chosen at random from among possible stances on four issues chosen to be representative of economic and socio-cultural debates in Poland: the scope of child benefit, changes to personal income tax, introducing LGBT partnerships, and the law on abortion. The inclusion of these policies was intended to ensure that illiberal policies were presented within a realistic context.

The third policy position was chosen at random from ten possibilities. Six of these reflect a position contrary to the tenets of liberal democracy, drawing on the operationalisation of attitudes to democracy in Claassen et al. (2025). These are:

- (1) governments should have the possibility to ignore court rulings that they regard as politically motivated;
- (2) governments should be able to bend the law to solve urgent social and political problems;
- (3) some citizens should be deprived of democratic rights on the basis of their political views;

- (4) minority groups whose protests disturb the values of the majority should be deprived of the right to protest;
- (5) governments should have the possibility to bend the rules in their favour if their predecessors have done so;
- (6) political decisions should be made by experts and not politicians or ordinary people.

These variables pertain both to the rule-of-law aspect of contemporary liberal democracy and to its polyarchic character.

The remaining four policy positions concern issues that are not directly related to liberal democracy. These were included to ensure that respondents were not only choosing between candidates with illiberal views. These policy positions are:

- (7) improving air quality by banning the sale of new cars that run on petrol;
- (8) increasing tax on the sale of cigarettes;
- (9) increasing access to state-funded childcare;
- (10) increasing investment in public schools.

These choice sets thus enable respondents to select between candidates who express a range of views on politically divisive and valence issues. In doing so, they may or may not be forced to consider whether to punish (or indeed, should they be so minded, to reward) a candidate for expressing illiberal views, or to overlook those views for the sake of other policy stances they agree with.

I modelled the responses to the conjoint questions using a multilevel logistic regression in which each of the 10 binary candidate choices – which form the dependent variable – are nested within respondents. The models were estimated within a Bayesian framework, which offers much greater flexibility for the analysis of quantities of interest. Models were estimated in R using the *brms* package (Bürkner 2017) and quantities of interest calculated using the *marginalEffects* package (Arel-Bundock, Greifer, and Heiss 2024). Rather than estimate the average marginal component effects per Hainmueller, Hopkins, and Yamamoto (2014), I follow Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley (2019) in estimating marginal means, which allow subgroup comparisons to be made between categories instead of relative to a reference category, and contrasts of marginal means to be taken to compare the probabilities of choices made by different configurations of respondents.

For H1, I estimated a model using the full set of candidate characteristics as independent variables. This makes it possible to evaluate the extent to which candidates are punished or rewarded for illiberal views, and to place this in the context of other, potentially relevant, factors. Having estimated the model, I calculated the marginal mean probability of choosing a candidate with each of the characteristics or policy preferences presented to respondents.

The remaining analyses require the use of respondent-level variables. For H2, I estimated a model in which liberal-democratic policy choices at the level of the candidate are interacted with a measure of affective polarisation for or against PiS and KO for each of the three waves. While the affective polarisation variable was only included in the first wave of the survey and is therefore time-invariant, the extent and persistent character of affective polarisation in the Polish case is well-established (Górska 2019; Horonziak 2022; Tworzecki 2019). The measure of affective polarisation was derived by subtracting self-declared liking for KO from liking for PiS, such that the resulting variable

runs from -10 (fully pro-KO; fully anti-PiS) to 10 (fully pro-PiS, fully anti-KO). This variable was then standardised by centring and dividing by two standard deviations (Gelman 2008). While the use of this variable restricts the analysis of polarisation to the main line of division in the Polish party system, this is justifiable given the centrality of the “PiS versus anti-PiS” discourse in recent years.

Following the estimation of this model, quantities of interest were derived by calculating contrasts in the marginal mean probability of choosing a candidate conditional on candidate policy and respondent position on the dimension of affective polarisation. Quantities were calculated for four measures of polarisation: the minimum value, corresponding to strongly pro-KO polarisation; the first quartile, corresponding to moderately pro-KO polarisation; the third quartile, corresponding to moderately pro-PiS polarisation; and the maximum value, corresponding to strongly pro-PiS polarisation. The resulting values represent the differences in the probability of voting for a candidate expressing an illiberal view when comparing respectively moderate and strong KO supporters with those of PiS.

For H3, I used the Claassen et al. (2025) 7-item battery of questions measuring support for liberal democracy to derive an index of liberal-democratic attitudes at each of the three waves. This index was interacted with the variable recording the six illiberal positions and the four additional issues, and with the measure of affective polarisation used for H2. I then calculated the marginal mean probability of choosing a candidate, conditional on candidate policy choices, citizens’ level of support for liberal democracy, and level of polarisation. To derive these figures, the values for polarisation were held at the minimum (strongly pro-KO) and maximum (strongly pro-PiS), and citizens’ support for liberal democracy was held at one standard deviation below the mean value, and one standard deviation above it. The resulting two plots show the differences in the probability that citizens will vote for a candidate expressing illiberal views, conditional on whether they support liberal democracy and in which direction they are polarised.

Results

The results of the analyses are presented as plots of the marginal means of probabilities or contrasts of marginal means for specified conjoint attributes. For each attribute, there are three point estimates: one from each wave of the survey. In the first two waves (April and October 2023), PiS was the incumbent party; in the third wave (April 2024), the KO-led coalition was the incumbent party. In the case of marginal means (H1), each of the points identifies the mean predicted probability that a candidate characterised by a certain attribute will be chosen. If this point falls left of the 50% centre line, it indicates that the candidate is on average less likely to be chosen on the basis of this feature; if on the right side of the centre line, that the candidate is more likely to be chosen. In the case of contrasts (H2 and H3), the 0% centre line marks the point at which there is no difference between two distinct categories of voter, while points falling to the left or right of the line indicate respectively a lower or higher propensity on the part of one group to select a given candidate.

The overall impact of illiberal candidate stances

Figure 1 displays marginal means for all attributes included in the conjoint model. It is evident that policy positions matter to a much greater extent than candidate features.

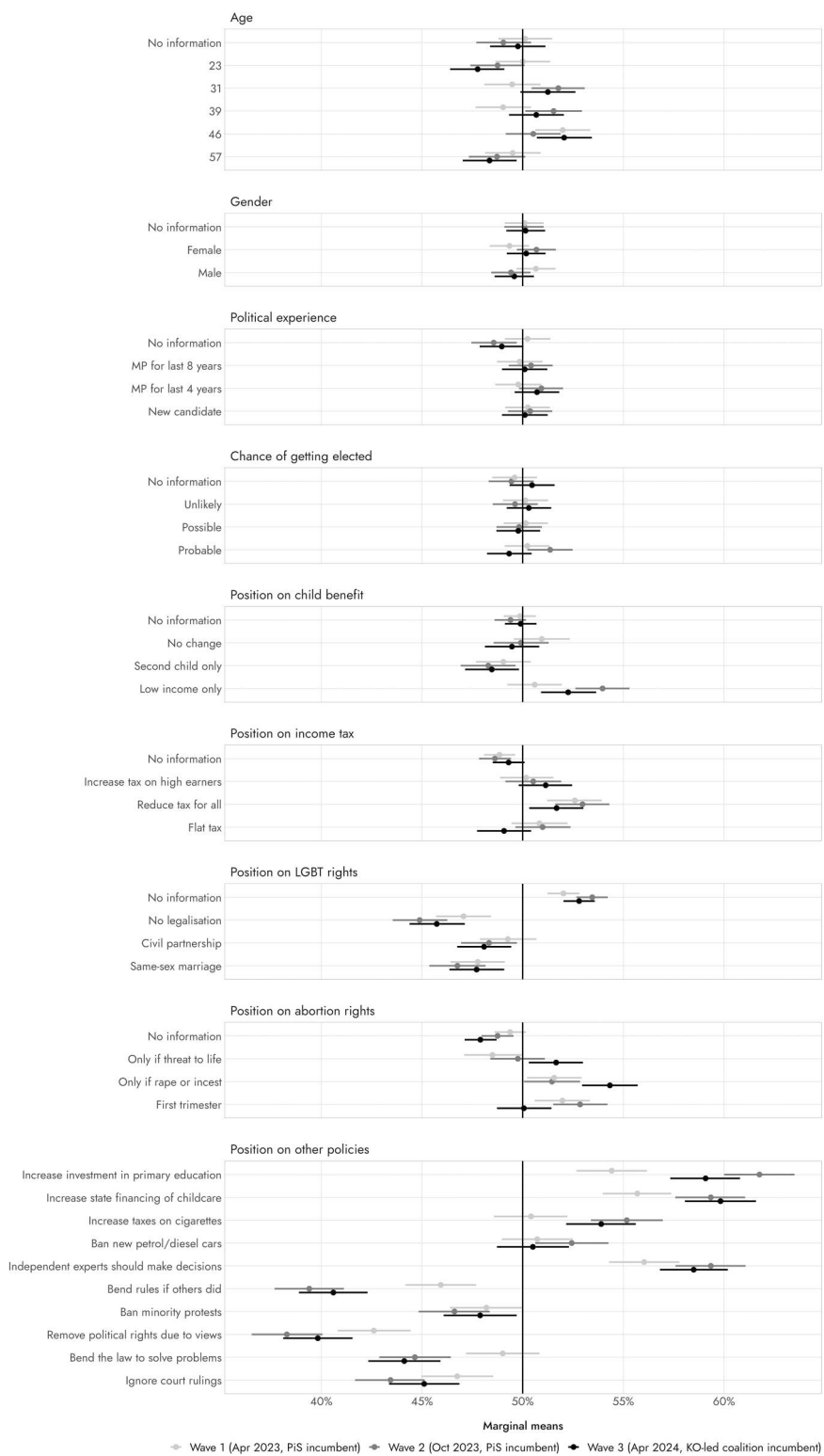


Figure 1. Marginal means of candidate selection probability, conditional on candidate attributes. Notes: The dots represent the effect of an attribute on the probability of choosing a candidate. The bars are 95% credible intervals. These quantities are estimated from a Bayesian multilevel logistic regression model with individual candidate selection choices nested inside respondents.

At least in the second and third waves, the youngest and oldest cohorts are less likely to be chosen, but there is no clear and consistent impact of gender or political experience, while the perceived chance of getting elected only moderately increases a candidate's chances of success.

The four key ideological stances have a more significant impact on the probability of candidate selection. Retaining the child benefit policy as currently implemented has only a slight impact, declining from around 51% to 49% over the three waves, while retaining the universality of the policy from an income perspective, but applying it only to households with more than one child, decreases the probability that a respondent will be selected. On the other hand, restricting the policy only to those with low incomes is likely to find favour with the average voter. On the question of income tax policy, candidates who advocate reducing the level of tax for all are more likely to be rewarded, while the outcome is more ambiguous in the case of increasing tax on high earners or advocating flat taxes, most probably as a result of partisan differences on this issue.

Where the two socio-cultural issues are concerned, there are clear differences. In general, Poles are disenchanted with candidates who take a clear stance on the issue of LGBT rights and exhibit a preference for those who do not take a specific position. While those who advocate no legalisation of same-sex relationships are more likely to be punished, voters also tend to respond negatively to calls for civil partnerships and same-sex marriage. Conversely, candidates are more likely to be punished if they do not take a stance on abortion, while explicit positions – ranging from extreme to liberal – tend to be rewarded by voters.

The final slate of policies consists of valence issues, issues that are not strongly associated with specific parties, and the illiberal positions that are of direct relevance to H1. In each wave, candidates are rewarded for advocating increased investment in primary education, increased state financing of childcare, increased taxes on cigarettes, and, to a lesser extent, the banning of new petrol or diesel cars. Among the six illiberal stances, the contention that independent experts, rather than elected politicians, should make decisions stands out from the others. In each of the three waves, this is associated with a greater than 5 percentage point increase in the probability of voting for a candidate. In all other cases, the illiberal stances are associated with a greater propensity to punish candidates, particularly in Waves 2 and 3 (both October 2023 and April 2024). In particular, candidates are judged negatively for advocating bending the rules in their favour if their predecessors have done so, or for advocating the removal of political rights from citizens on the basis of their views.

The overall picture lends qualified support to H1. With the exception of “independent experts should make decisions”, the average Polish voter punishes rather than rewards candidates for holding illiberal views. This is a consistent position, in the sense that across all three waves candidates are punished. However, while the results for Waves 2 and 3 are very similar, in Wave 1 respondents had on average a somewhat less punitive attitude towards illiberal candidates, indicating a degree of flexibility in the extent to which Poles are willing to accept illiberal stances.

The impact of affective polarisation

Figure 2 presents the results of the models in which candidates' illiberal stances are interacted with the measure of affective polarisation. It plots contrasts between respectively

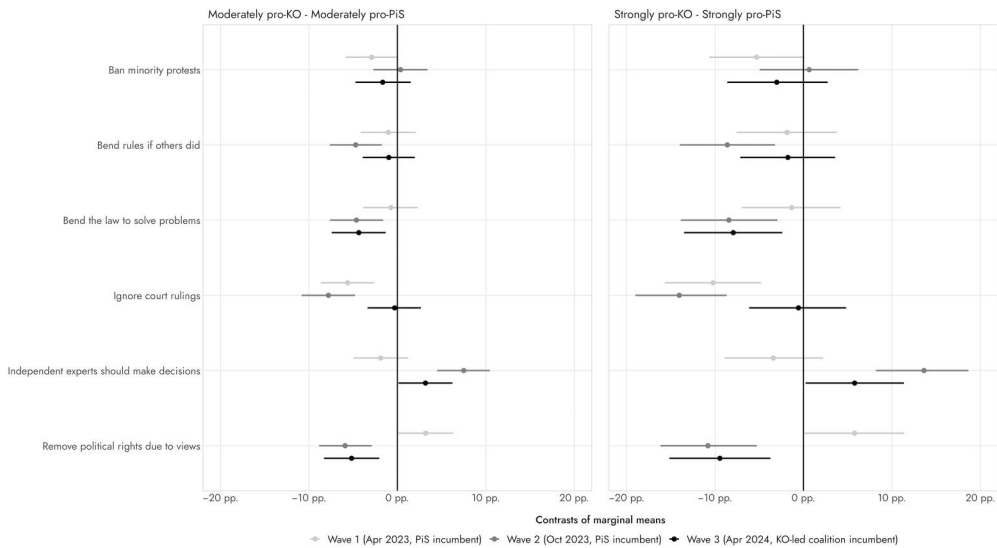


Figure 2. Contrasts of marginal mean probabilities of selecting a candidate, conditional on the extent of a citizen's affective polarisation. Notes: The dots represent the percentage point change in the probability of choosing a candidate when comparing pro-KO citizens with pro-PiS citizens, at different levels of affective polarisation. The bars are 95% credible intervals. These quantities are estimated from a Bayesian multilevel logistic regression model with individual candidate selection choices nested inside respondents.

moderately and strongly polarised citizens. A point on the centre line corresponds to no difference between the two groups. If the point falls to the right of the centre line, it indicates that those who are polarised in favour of PiS are more likely than those who are polarised in favour of KO supporters to punish candidates for illiberal policy stances, while if the point falls to the left of the centre line, PiS supporters are less likely than KO supporters to punish illiberalism.

The findings only partly support H2. In most cases, those polarised in favour of PiS are less likely to punish candidates for illiberal stances than their KO-supporting counterparts, or there is no significant difference. The picture is more varied in the case of technocracy: while in Wave 1 (April 2023, PiS incumbent) PiS supporters were more likely than KO supporters to punish those stating that experts rather than elected politicians should make decisions, in Wave 2 (October 2023, PiS incumbent) and – to a lesser extent – Wave 3 (April 2024, KO-led coalition incumbent), they were less likely to punish such candidates. These relationships hold both for moderately and strongly polarised respondents. Overall, there is moderate support for the hypothesis that supporters of PiS would be less likely than supporters of KO to punish candidates for illiberal stances prior to the change of government, when PiS was the incumbent party (H2a). However, the results from the third, post-electoral, wave – when the KO-led coalition was the incumbent party – largely do not support the hypothesis that PiS supporters are more likely to punish illiberalism after the change of government (H2b). In the case of banning minority protests, bending the law to solve problems, and removing political rights from citizens on account of their views, PiS supporters remain less likely to punish candidates. The only significant difference concerns whether governments should ignore court rulings. In

this case, while supporters of PiS were more likely to reward candidates with illiberal views on this matter prior to the change of government, after the change of government there was no difference between PiS and KO supporters on this question.¹

The impact of attitudes towards liberal democracy and affective polarisation

Figure 3 presents the results of the model interacting candidate positions on policy issues with citizens' attitudes to liberal democracy and their level of affective polarisation. The results are plotted as contrasts of marginal means when moving from strongly pro-KO to strongly pro-PiS, disaggregated into two plots for citizens with illiberal attitudes and liberal attitudes respectively.

In both cases, the centre line denotes a situation when polarisation makes no difference to the probability of selecting candidates. If the point estimates fall to the left of this line, then being strongly polarised in favour of KO is associated with a lower probability of selecting a candidate with illiberal views than in the case of being strongly polarised towards PiS. If the points are to the right of the centre line, the opposite applies.

If democratic hypocrisy exists, then liberal democratic attitudes should not alter the impact of affective polarisation on candidate choice, with pro-liberal citizens being as opportunistic in their choices as their illiberal counterparts. The results of the previous analysis show that at the overall level there is little evidence to suggest that with a change of government came a change of behaviour with respect to voting for illiberal candidates. On the evidence of Figure 3, attitudes to liberal democracy do not significantly alter the picture. The main difference is evident in the case of banning minority

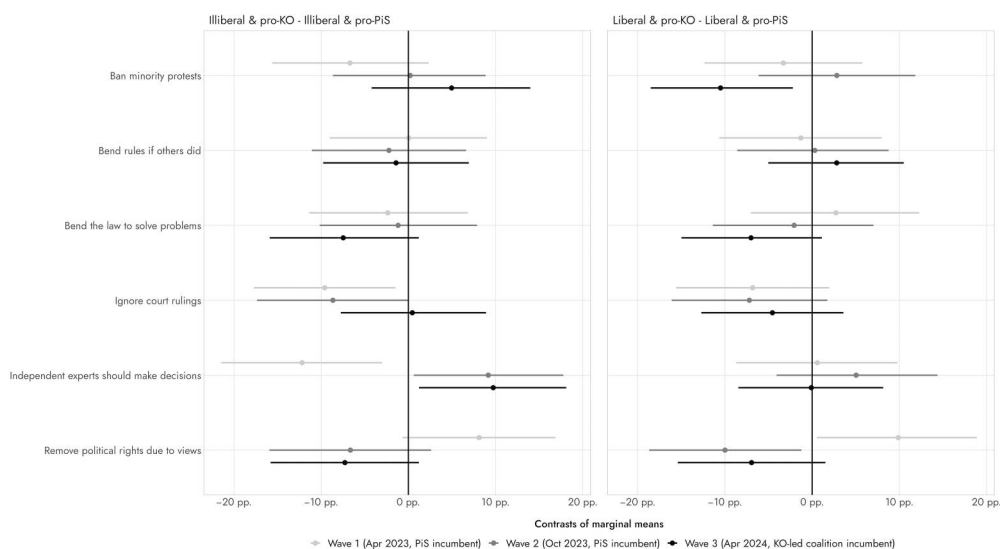


Figure 3. Contrasts of marginal mean probabilities of selecting a candidate, conditional on candidate attributes and respondent attitudes to liberal democracy. Notes: The dots represent the percentage point change in the probability of choosing a candidate when comparing strongly pro-KO citizens with strongly pro-PiS citizens, at different levels of declared attitudes towards liberal democracy. The bars are 95% credible intervals. These quantities are estimated from a Bayesian multilevel logistic regression model with individual candidate selection choices nested inside respondents.

protests. While in the third wave (April 2024, KO-led coalition incumbent) pro-KO citizens who have illiberal attitudes were more likely than their illiberal pro-PiS counterparts to vote for a candidate who holds this view, pro-KO citizens who were also pro-liberal-democracy were 10 pp. less likely to vote for such a candidate in the third wave. This runs contrary to what would be expected in conditions of democratic hypocrisy. Similarly, while illiberal pro-KO citizens were as likely as their pro-PiS counterparts to vote for a candidate who advocates ignoring court rulings, liberal pro-KO citizens were more likely to punish such a candidate. These results thus indicate that H3 is not upheld.

Discussion

The above findings advance the literature on responses to democratic backsliding by examining how citizens' democratic preferences evolve during an actual transition from democratic backsliding to re-consolidation, rather than relying on hypothetical scenarios. Previous work has largely focused on how citizens respond to backsliding in the moment, or how they might potentially respond to changes in power. The use of panel data spanning a real democratic transition – from PiS incumbency to KO-led coalition incumbency – provides rare insight into whether and how citizens adjust their democratic preferences as power changes hands.

The findings both confirm and challenge existing theories. The study is in line with previous research showing that citizens generally punish illiberal candidates, showing that even in cases where there has been significant democratic backsliding, baseline democratic norms persist not only in a declarative sense. Yet the relationship between democratic backsliding and citizen preferences is more complex than the existing literature suggests. Contrary to expectations, PiS supporters did not become significantly more supportive of democratic protections after losing power, nor did KO supporters become significantly less supportive after gaining power. This suggests that even when democratic hypocrisy exists at the level of declared intentions, there is no guarantee that it will manifest itself in actual behaviour.

The absence of the expected reversal in behaviour following the change of government requires further consideration. Several explanations may account for the non-confirmation of H2b. First, revealed preferences may be inherently “stickier” than declared preferences, because they are embedded in more complex decision-making contexts where other considerations, such as policy agreement, candidate quality and perceived electability, anchor choices and reduce the scope for purely partisan reasoning. Second, the asymmetry of the Polish case may play a role: PiS supporters' greater tolerance for illiberalism may reflect a deep ideological commitment rooted in the party's longstanding scepticism toward liberal constitutionalism (Bill and Stanley 2025b), rather than the kind of instrumental calculation that would be expected to reverse with a change of power. Third, the relatively short interval between the formation of the new government in December 2023 and the third wave of the survey in April 2024 may not have allowed sufficient time for behavioural adjustment. The full consequences of a change of power – including the experience of being on the receiving end of executive authority – may take longer to manifest in the kinds of multidimensional choices captured by a conjoint experiment. Similarly, the frustrations of trying to resolve the post-illiberal trilemma may take time to become evident to supporters of a government

which has come to power on the promise to restore liberal democracy, particularly if those supporters were minded to extend a “honeymoon” of good will and patience.

One finding that merits particular attention is the consistent outlier status of the technocratic position – the view that independent experts, rather than elected politicians, should make political decisions. Unlike the other illiberal stances, this position was associated with a *higher* probability of candidate selection across all three waves, regardless of partisan affiliation or the direction of affective polarisation. This suggests that support for technocratic governance may reflect a widespread disillusionment with the performance of political elites that cuts across partisan lines, rather than an illiberal impulse in the conventional sense. As Caramani (2017) has argued, the technocratic challenge to democracy is distinct from the populist one, even if both share a scepticism of representative politics. The consistent appeal of technocratic candidates complicates the binary liberal/illiberal framing that underpins much of the democratic backsliding literature, and suggests that future research should attend more carefully to the different forms that dissatisfaction with liberal democracy can take.

There are thus some reasons to be optimistic about the prospects for democratic resilience. The consistent punishment of illiberal positions suggests that basic democratic commitments can persist even through situations of institutional stress. The limited role played by affective polarisation in amplifying illiberal tendencies suggests that while significant social tensions may continue to roil contemporary democracies, they may not be sufficient to undermine liberal democracy in its entirety. Yet the stability of revealed preferences is a double-edged sword. On the one hand, the persistent punishment of illiberal candidates suggests a reservoir of democratic commitment that post-illiberal governments can draw upon. On the other, the absence of a “democratic bounce” among former incumbents’ supporters – who did not become notably more protective of liberal-democratic norms after losing power – suggests that democratic restoration cannot rely on a natural correction in public attitudes. Rebuilding liberal democracy after a period of backsliding requires active investment in democratic norms, institutions, and civic education, not passive expectation of a return to equilibrium. This is a sobering finding for those who hope that simply removing illiberal incumbents will suffice to restore democratic health. It is consistent with the observation that in the Polish case “both liberal elites and supporters of liberal-democratic parties see these norms as subordinate to more-immediate concerns and interests” (Bill and Stanley 2025a, 26), and it underscores the importance of attending to the demand side of democratic politics in the aftermath of backsliding.

The study is subject to a number of limitations that should be borne in mind when interpreting its findings. First, while the panel was designed to minimise the impact of attrition on the socio-demographic representativeness of the sample, attrition over the three waves may nevertheless introduce a bias toward more politically engaged and attentive respondents, who may be less representative of the broader population in terms of their democratic commitments. Second, while the conjoint design mitigates social desirability bias by embedding illiberal positions within realistic candidate profiles, it nonetheless presents stylised choices that may not fully capture the complexity of real electoral decision-making. Third, the single-country design, while providing the depth necessary to study an actual transition from illiberal to liberal-democratic government, limits the generalisability of the findings to other contexts of democratic

backsliding and recovery. Fourth, the use of a time-invariant measure of affective polarisation, collected only in the first wave, may not capture shifts in the intensity or direction of polarisation that occurred as a consequence of the change of government itself, although, as the robustness test in Figure A1 demonstrates, the extent of polarisation in Poland is such that in this case it is unlikely to have a significant impact.

The study of democratic hypocrisy is still at an early stage, particularly with respect to its manifestations in actual contexts of democratic backsliding and recovery, rather than hypothetical circumstances. To an extent, this is unavoidable, as there are few cases of arrested backsliding to study. Yet even in cases where incumbents remain attached to liberal democratic norms and institutions, the further use of longitudinal studies will illuminate how persistent declared and revealed preferences for liberal democracy are, and thus how vulnerable they might be to future subversion. Future research should examine the conditions under which affective polarisation is more or less consequential for democratic hypocrisy, and whether the patterns observed here – where the change of power did not significantly alter revealed preferences – hold in other contexts of democratic backsliding and recovery. Notably, survey evidence from the same period as the third wave of the panel survey used in this study indicates that strong KO supporters who declared a preference for legality were nonetheless willing to endorse dubiously legal government actions when presented with a realistic scenario (Bill and Stanley 2025a, 25–26). This convergence of declared-preference evidence with the revealed-preference findings reported here suggests that further research combining both approaches within a single design could yield a richer understanding of how democratic hypocrisy operates across different modes of political choice.

Note

1. This is corroborated by Figure A1 in the Appendix, which provides a robustness test of the polarisation findings by using a measure of consistent voting across the three waves of the survey. Those who consistently voted for KO were, with the exception of responses to “Independent experts make decisions”, more likely than those who consistently voted for PiS to punish a candidate for holding illiberal views.

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